

POWERPLAY — Player Primer

A first-timer's walkthrough. Read this once, then keep the four reference cards (Quick / Round / Turn / Mechanics) handy at the table.

1. Welcome to the Boardroom

PowerPlay is a corporate-satire strategy card and token game for **3–5 players**. Each player runs a thinly-disguised shell of an industrial empire, trying to amass more **Power** than the rest of the table by the end of the fiscal year.

You'll buy **Assets** (Tier 1 → Tier 3), play **Actions** to attack the competition, **React** when you're attacked, and convert **Coins** → **Influence** → **Power** at every opportunity.

Game length depends on mode:

- **Standard** (3–5 players): 6 rounds.
- **Blitz** (5 players): 4 rounds. The second turn of each round goes counter-clockwise — Silicon Valley pacing.
- **Long-Term** (3 players): 8 rounds. Build massive portfolios; weather multiple market crashes.

"In a free market, your value is whatever you can convince someone else it is."

2. What's on the Table

The CEOs have catered the boardroom. When the table is set up, you should see:

- **11 card piles:**
 - 3 **Action** piles (T1, T2, T3) — what you do TO other players.
 - 3 **Reaction** piles (T1, T2, T3) — how you respond when something happens TO you.
 - 3 **Asset** piles (T1, T2, T3) — the companies you buy that generate income.
 - 1 **Event** deck — the market events that hit everyone at the start of each round.
 - 1 **Character** deck — the personas you'll pick from at setup.
- **Per-player counters** (one set at each seat): **Power (P)**, **Influence (IP)**, **Coins (C)**, **Loans**.
- **Per-color IOU template** (one per seat color) — used to record debts owed to that color player.
- **One d6 die** for income rolls.
- **One Leader Token** that travels around the table each round.

△ Quick orientation: Power is the win condition. Influence buys aggression (Actions, Reactions). Coins buy Assets and pay debts. You'll convert between them constantly.

3. Setup, Step by Step (The Shareholder Onboarding Packet)

1. **Pick a character.** The Character deck is the only deck dealt face-up at setup — each player picks one. Your character has printed **Starting Stats** (Coins, Influence, Power) and a special **Character Ability**. Set your counters to those starting values.
2. **Deal Starting Hand.** Each player draws **3 Action cards from the T1 Action pile** and **2 Reaction cards from the T1 Reaction pile**. T1 cards are free to play, with no Power requirement — every player can use their starting hand immediately. (Per RC-Z16-01.)
3. **Determine the Leader.** Whichever player has the **highest starting Power** gets the **Leader Token** for Round 1. If multiple players tie, dice off.
4. **Hand size limit at end of turn:** 3 Actions + 2 Reactions max during Conclude. (No limit during your own turn — you can hold whatever you draw mid-turn.)
5. **Confirm the mode:** Standard / Blitz / Long-Term. This sets the round count.
6. **Done.** Your first Inception phase begins now.

△ Tip: Don't agonize over character choice — every character is built to a 22-point equity standard, so there's no objectively-best pick. Pick the one whose ability fits how you like to play (aggressive vs. defensive vs. economic).

4. The Round in 3 Phases (One Fiscal Quarter)

The market opens, the market gossips, the market closes. Every round runs in this order:

Phase 1 — Inception

- **Market Shock:** Draw 1 Event card from the Event deck. Resolve it. Some Events fire once and end ("one-shot"); others stay active until Call-it-a-Night ("ongoing").
- **Pre-Market Auction:** In turn order starting with the Leader, each player picks one Asset deck (T1 / T2 / T3 — gated by Buy Floor: 0 P / 1 P / 2 P), draws the top card, and that card goes up for auction. Bidding goes **clockwise from the drawer's left**, and **the drawer bids last** (they get the final yes-or-no). Highest bidder pays the bank and acquires the Asset. No bids → the card is discarded. Repeats until every player has drawn once.

*⚠ **Auction subtlety:** You're not obligated to buy the card you drew. Sometimes you want to expose a card you can't afford so a competitor has to spend their Coins to get it.*

Phase 2 — Opening Bell

- Every player takes **two turns**, clockwise from the Leader.
- Each turn is a mini-cycle: **Initiate** → **Action** → **Conclude** (next section).
- In **Blitz Mode** only: the second pass around the table reverses direction. Whoever played their first turn **LAST** plays their second turn **FIRST**, then play continues counter-clockwise (right). The Leader plays last before CIAN.

Phase 3 — Call-it-a-Night (CIAN)

End-of-round housekeeping. In this order:

1. **Earnings Call & Trading:** brag, swap intel, trade Coins / Influence / Power / Assets / IOUs freely. Trades are binding.
2. **Currency Conversion:** convert Tokens at the standard rates — **3 C = 1 IP, 2 IP = 1 P**. Any amounts.
3. **Debt Settlement** (loans + IOUs — see § 8 for details).
4. **Thievery:** if the **lowest-Power player** isn't already the Leader, they take the Leader Token and assign it to ANY player — including themselves. Ties → earliest player in turn order decides.

If this wasn't the final round, the next round starts at Inception. If it was, run **Clean the Books** (all outstanding loans settle now) and then **Board Meeting** (final scoring).

5. The Turn in 3 Phases (Your Time on the Mic)

Every turn — your turn — runs in this order. Make it billable.

A. Initiate

- **Draw 1 card** (Action OR Reaction) from a tier pile you meet the Power Floor for. ($T1 = 0 P$, $T2 = 1 P$, $T3 = 2 P$. Power is checked, not spent — playing the card doesn't cost Power; the floor is just a gate.)
- **Collect Revenue:** roll **1d6 per Asset Tier you own** (separate rolls for T1, T2, T3 — not one die per Asset). Look up the Fiscal Table; that's your gross income for each tier. Pay **Operating Costs first** (T2 Assets: 1 C each; T3 Assets: 2 C each; T1 Assets: none). What's left is the Coin payout you collect.
- **Forced Bankruptcy:** if income minus Op Costs is negative and you can't cover from reserves, enter Bankruptcy Resolution before continuing.
- **Market Operations** (optional, 1 free choice):
 - **Broker an Asset Deal:** pay a Brokerage Fee (1 C for T1, 2 C for T2, 3 C for T3), draw the top 2 cards from one Asset deck you meet the Buy Floor for, buy one at printed cost, discard the other.
 - **Buy an Action Card:** pay 1 C → draw the top of an Action tier pile you meet the Power Floor for.
 - **Buy a Reaction Card:** pay 2 C → draw the top of a Reaction tier pile you meet the Power Floor for.

B. Action

You must take **exactly one Standard Action** from this menu:

- **Play an Action card** — pay its tier cost (T1 free / T2 1 IP / T3 2 IP), resolve the effects.
- **Sell an Asset** — to the bank for its printed cost. (Player-to-player Asset trades happen only during CIAN trading.)
- **Take a Loan** — borrow up to floor(printed Asset cost / 2) Coins from the supply, secured against one of your Assets (which becomes Mortgaged). Max 2 active loans / player.
- **Skip** — gain 2 Coins from the supply, do nothing else.

Free Actions don't consume your Standard Action:

- **Character Ability** — once per round (across both your turns), paid in IP or Power as printed on the character card. Never costs Coins. **Sacred** — cannot be Countered, Cancelled, Prevented, or Redirected.
- **PowerPlay!** — pay 1 P → **+1 Standard Action this turn** AND draw 1 Action + 1 Reaction. Once per turn. **Sacred**.

⚠ Big subtle rule: +1 Standard Action from Events, Investment Bank, or PowerPlay! **stacks** even after you've spent your starter action. So PowerPlay! into a second Action card play is a common combo when you have the Power to spend.

C. Conclude

- **Discard** down to exactly **3 Action + 2 Reaction** cards.
- **Voluntary loan repayment** (free) — pay principal + 1 C → the mortgaged Asset is freed.
- **Loan cap check** — if you have 3+ active loans, default one of your choice now (it discharges per Loan default rules).
- **Attach cleanup** — remove any expired Attached cards from your Assets and from yourself.
- **Unfreeze** every frozen Asset you own. (Frozen Assets can't be Used this turn.)

6. What Can I Do on My Turn? (The Quarterly Strategy Memo)

A common new-player confusion: **what exactly counts as a "Standard Action"**? The Board pays for exactly one per turn. Everything else is "free" — though in PowerPlay, "free" usually means paid for in some other resource. Reference:

Choice	Cost	Effect
Play Action card	Tier cost (T1 free / T2 1 IP / T3 2 IP)	Resolve the card's effect on its target.
Sell Asset	Free (-1 Asset)	Bank pays you the Asset's printed cost.
Take Loan	Lien on Asset	Bank pays you up to floor(cost/2). Asset becomes Mortgaged.
Skip	Free	Gain 2 C.

And these are NOT Standard Actions — they don't use up your Action slot:

Free	When	Effect
Character Ability	Any time on your turn (once per round)	Pay IP or Power per card; resolve. Sacred.
PowerPlay!	Any time on your turn (once per turn)	Pay 1 P → +1 Standard Action + draw 1 A + 1 R. Sacred.
Use Asset Ability	When trigger fires (per card)	Some Assets activate automatically; some need you to declare them.
Market Operations	Initiate Phase only	Choose ONE (Broker / Buy Action / Buy Reaction).
Voluntary loan repay	Own Conclude or CIAN	Pay principal + 1 C → Asset unmortgaged.

Example turn: It's your turn. Initiate — you draw 1 T2 Action (because your Power is 2). Income roll: 1d6 = 4 on your T2 die → you collect 2 C per T2 Asset; pay 1 C Op Cost each. You skip Market Operations. Action phase — you play your T2 Action card "Hostile Takeover" paying 1 IP (cost) and target an opponent's T1 Asset. They Counter with a T2 Reaction. You PowerPlay! (1 P), giving yourself a +1 Standard Action;

draw 1 A + 1 R. Use your new Standard Action to play "Smear Campaign" T2 paying 1 IP. Conclude — discard down to 3 A + 2 R; unfreeze your Assets. Done.

⚠ **Newbie trap:** You may have only **1 Standard Action**, but you can also use **1 Character Ability** and **1 PowerPlay!** in the same turn. Plus you can play Reactions on other players' turns. The "I can only do one thing" feeling is wrong — read the Turn Reference Card carefully.

7. Reactions and How to Defend Yourself (Crisis Comms)

Reactions are cards you play **out of turn** — interrupts. They live in your hand the same way Actions do, and you can throw one any time a relevant trigger fires. Think of them as the legal team on retainer: you wait until something bad is happening, then unleash them.

Three things to know:

1. **Counter Tier-Up:** Lower-tier Actions are easier to Counter than higher-tier ones.
 - A T1 Action can be Countered by any tier of Reaction.
 - A T2 Action can be Countered by T2 or T3 Reactions only.
 - A T3 Action can be Countered by T3 Reactions only.
2. **Reaction-vs-Reaction is tier-flat:** any Reaction can target any other Reaction. (Used to extend a chain or block someone else's defense.)
3. **Chains cap at 2 Reactions** per Action / Event chain. So your opponent's Counter can be Re-Countered once, but no further.

⚠ **Reactor vocabulary:** The player who plays a Reaction is called the **Reactor**. You can Reaction-defend YOURSELF or any other player. If you defend someone else and your Reaction has an Industry Synergy, the synergy checks YOUR Assets, not the Defender's.

Sacred actions cannot be Countered — character abilities, PowerPlay!, and any play explicitly marked Sacred bypass Reactions entirely.

8. Money, Loans, and Going Broke (Capital Discipline)

Currency conversion

At CIAN (only), or any time a card explicitly allows it:

- **3 Coins = 1 Influence**
- **2 Influence = 1 Power**

Going the other way isn't allowed.

Loans

Take a Loan as your Standard Action. The bank pays you up to **floor(Asset cost / 2)** Coins; you lien an Asset of your choice as collateral (it's now **Mortgaged**).

- **Max 2 active loans** per player.
- **Maintenance fee:** 1 C per active loan at CIAN, **except** the round you acquired the loan (grace round).
- **Voluntary repay** (free at your own Conclude or CIAN): pay **principal + 1 C** → the Asset is unmortgaged.
- **Default** (missed maintenance OR over-cap): the mortgaged Asset goes to the discard pile, the bank pays you its printed cost, you pay back the loan dues, and you **keep the surplus** (1 C / 3 C / 6 C for T1/T2/T3). No elimination from loan default.
- **Mortgaged Assets still earn income** — the loan just claims the collateral if you default.

IOUs

If an Action card demands a resource you don't have (insufficient IP, Power, or Coin), you take a **Coin-denominated IOU** to the Attacker instead.

Shortfall	IOU value (per missing unit)
1 IP	4 C (3 + 1 interest)
1 P	7 C (6 + 1 interest)

1 C	(X + 1) C
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- **Cap:** max 2 NEW IOUs per Defender per round. Subsequent debt-triggers floor at 0 (you just can't pay anymore).
- **Settlement:** at CIAN, in Debt Settlement after Currency Conversion. Voluntary repay first, then negotiation, then forced liquidation.
- **Negotiation is open-ended:** forgive part, trade an Asset for partial credit, swap for future favors (non-binding!). Both parties have to agree.
- **Tradable:** IOUs themselves can be traded during CIAN — the IOU holder transfers the debt to a third party.

Bankruptcy

Going to 0 Coins isn't bankrupt — you're just broke. **Bankrupt** means you owe Coins and can't pay even after liquidating every unencumbered Asset. Outcomes:

- **Loan default → NOT elimination.** The bank takes the Asset; you keep the surplus.
- **IOU default WITH negotiable agreement → NOT elimination.** The Attacker forgives, partial-pays, or accepts an Asset trade.
- **IOU default with no unencumbered Assets AND no agreement → elimination.** Your owed IOUs and any held IOUs are wiped from play.

▲ **Cushion strategy:** Keep at least 1 unencumbered (un-mortgaged) Asset in reserve. It's your safety net against forced IOU liquidation.

9. How You Win (The Board Meeting)

At the end of the final Round, after the last Call-it-a-Night runs, the Board convenes to determine who walks out the **POWER PLAYER**. Two steps happen:

1. **Clean the Books:** every outstanding loan settles now. Pay principal + 1 C to clear, or default (asset → discard, bank pays you printed cost, you keep the surplus). **No elimination from loan default at this step either.**
2. **Board Meeting** — final scoring:

```
Total Power = Power
              + floor(IP / 2)
              + floor(Coins / 6)
              + floor(Asset Value / 5)
```

Where "Asset Value" is the sum of printed costs of every Asset you still own (4 C / 8 C / 14 C for T1/T2/T3).

▲ **Why the rates differ:** Coins score at $/6$, Asset Value at $/5$. Owning Assets is intentionally a slightly better long-term score-per-token than hoarding liquid Coins. Convert Coins to Assets when you can. (RC-REF1-01.)

Highest Total Power wins. Ties broken by best-of-three Rock / Paper / Scissors / Lizard / Spock. (Yes, really.)

Sample scoring: Player ends with **5 Power, 7 Influence, 15 Coins**, two T2 Assets (printed cost 8 C each = 16 C Asset Value).

```
Total Power = 5 + floor(7/2) + floor(15/6) + floor(16/5)
              = 5 + 3 + 2 + 3
              = 13
```

Note: the same player with 15 Coins under the old $\text{floor}(C/5)$ rule would have scored 14. The new rate makes Asset holdings increasingly attractive as the game progresses.

10. Where to Look Next (The Compliance Library)

The four reference cards on the table — keep them visible; the Board appreciates due diligence:

- **Quick Reference** ([PowerPlay_QuickReference.pdf](#)) — one-page summary of every system. Keep this in front of you.
- **Round Reference Card** ([PowerPlay_RoundReferenceCard.pdf](#)) — one-page detailed walkthrough of Inception → Opening Bell → CIAN.

- **Turn Reference Card** (`PowerPlay_TurnReferenceCard.pdf`) — one-page detailed walkthrough of Initiate → Action → Conclude.
- **Mechanics Reference Card** (`PowerPlay_MechanicsReferenceCard.pdf`) — every named mechanic (Power Floor, Sacred, Counter Tier-Up, IOU, Loan, Attach, etc.) defined precisely.

The full rules manual (`PowerPlay_Manual_03072026.pdf`) is comprehensive — but the four cards above will get you through almost every situation that comes up at the table. Save the manual for rules debates and edge cases.

Good luck. Try not to get eliminated. And if you do, remember: it's only fictional money.

Source of all rules: `documents/POWERPLAY OFFICIAL INSTRUCTIONS 03072026.md` . REF-1 (2026-05-12).